

straight time to stop fast-rising Victoria Mboko 6-1, 7-6(1) and make the quarterfinals. The World No. 1 then put her foot down on another hot prospect, 29th-seeded Iva Jovic, 6-3, 6-0. "It was a tough match. Don't look at the score," said Sabalenka. "She played incredible tennis, and she pushed me to a one-step-better level. It was a battle." Jovic, whose father is Serbian, benefited from some tips that fellow Serb Djokovic texted her during her breakthrough Slam tournament. The 18-year-old, slender 5'6" Californian with superb strokes earlier upset the even shorter 5'4", No. 7-seeded Jasmine Paolini, the 2024 French and Wimbledon finalist, 6-2, 7-6(3).

The resurgence of Elina Svitolina, following maternity leave, accelerated at Melbourne. The former world No. 3 from Ukraine earned a semifinal berth with an impressive 6-2, 6-4 victory over No. 8-seeded teen star Mirra Andrejeva and a stunning 6-1, 6-2 win over two-time Major champion Gauff. "It means the world to me," said the ecstatic Svitolina. "I try to push myself and find the motivation to continue. I'm really happy to go through to the semifinals. It's been my goal to come back to the Top 10 after maternity leave."

On No. 3 seed Gauff's inept performance against the rock-solid, consistent Svitolina, *BBC* analyst and former tour player Laura Robson said, "It was so surprising to see her come out [like that]. She's usually a big-match player, so consistent and mentally tough — and she looked lost." A scant three winners against 26 unforced errors tell not all, but much, of the story. Was the problem a matter of technique? Gauff had a mediocre 21-9 match record from her Roland Garros title to the start of the Australian Open largely because either her forehand or serve, or both, broke down. "Is my serve where I want it to be? No," she acknowledged. Or was it a psychological crisis? Gauff herself wondered, saying, "It's like a fine line between playing as if your life depends on it and it doesn't depend on it."

When tournament cameras



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showed her smashing her racquet in frustration in a corridor in the players' area, the incident went viral. "Living and learning. But still will keep trying to move forward," Gauff explained on X. "Also, I'm a real person with real feelings ... I care a lot and I'm trying my best. Thank you to those who understand that."

Wings of future

In an all-American fourth-round match, Jessica Pegula, the 2024 U.S. Open finalist, eliminated a nervous, error-prone Keys, the defending Australian Open champion, 6-3, 6-4. "Jessica Pegula and Amanda Anisimova are just waiting in the wings to win a Major," commented

Chris Evert, the *ESPN* analyst who won 18 singles Majors in the 1970s and '80s. Both would have to wait at least until the French Open in June. Although four American women made the AO quarterfinals for the first time since 2001 — and at any Major since the 2017 U.S. Open — only one, Pegula, reached the semis Down Under on her fourth try, defeating Anisimova 6-2, 7-6(1). The down-to-earth daughter of billionaire parents, Pegula, heeded the smart advice of coach Mark Merklein — "Pressure her second serve" — by moving three feet inside the baseline and attacking it. (The Australian Open is the only Major with the coach's box